Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Steve Kowit's "The Grammar Lesson"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's tone in Steve Kowit's "The Grammar Lesson," the tone the speaker uses while instructing his audience to "[j]ust / memorize the [sic] rules" include

ambiguity,
antecedent,
definition,
enjambment,
hyperbole,
imagery,
intentional fallacy,
litotes,
ploce,
pun,
repetition,
rhyme,
rhyme scheme,
speaker,
tone, and
villanelle.

The contestant should recognize the poem's closed form as the villanelle, a form, the conventions/ expectations, rules of which are violated several times: the repetition of lines is not exact. The contestant might focus on the subtle violation of standard, and especially, formal language use in presentation of a grammar lesson.

The young writer might begin with the speaker's "See? There's almost nothing to it," arguing that the rhetorical construct is, by way of litotes or, perhaps, hyperbole, a negation of the "ease" suggested by the lesson up to this point.

Either approach should lead to an appreciation of the speaker's tone as amused, cynical, mildly derisive, facetious, humorous, lighthearted, naïve, satirical, or whimsical—each of which is defensible . . . to a degree.